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Assignment 3: Reflections and Lessons from the Internship

This past summer I had the privilege of working at Santa Clara University's Financial Aid Office for 19 hours a week, where I supported the operational and data management processes critical to student financial aid. My responsibilities included reviewing and updating student financial records, reconciling complex spreadsheets in Google Sheets with Workday entries, filing student records, and cross-checking internal documentation to ensure compliance and accuracy in aid distribution. I also assisted in processing scholarships and managing sensitive records, requiring a high level of precision and confidentiality. I also supported outreach efforts by tabling and providing student-facing assistance during Orientation weeks in July, helping connect students with resources such as the Federal Work-Study program and reinforcing the office's commitment to equity in higher education access.

During my time at the Financial Aid Office, I learned how important accuracy and confidentiality are when working with student records. I became more confident using systems like Workday and Google Sheets to check data, reconcile information, and keep files organized. I also learned how to handle sensitive financial information carefully, making sure everything was correct before it was processed. As a student, it was exciting to learn more about how financial aid actually works. Many people know what financial aid is, but not everyone realizes the behind-the-scenes work that staff do to process scholarships and ensure funds are correctly applied to students' accounts. I also organized and filed many student records, which further

improved my attention to detail. I had to be careful to place each file in the correct folder, since any mistake could affect accuracy and cause delays in processing aid and posting scholarships to student accounts. On the student-facing side, I gained experience explaining financial aid terms in simple ways, which helped me practice turning complex information into clear answers. This taught me that the job requires not only technical skills but also strong communication to support students effectively.

What surprised me most was the amount of work that goes on behind the scenes to make sure that financial aid is disbursed promptly. I hadn't realized how many checks, balances, and manual processes are involved, even within advanced systems like Workday. I was also amazed by how much teamwork and cross-departmental coordination goes into maintaining accuracy. Financial aid is not just about numbers, but also about communication and trust. Additionally, I was surprised at how rewarding it felt to directly assist students during Orientation weeks, seeing how financial aid directly impacts their access to higher education.

My experience at the Financial Aid Office gave me a strong foundation in managing sensitive records, maintaining accuracy across multiple systems, and supporting students with professionalism. Reconciling spreadsheets with Workday entries trained me to be detail-oriented and methodical, skills that I can emphasize in any role requiring precision in data management. Working with financial aid records also taught me the value of confidentiality and compliance, which shows that I can manage sensitive data appropriately. In addition to the technical aspects, helping students during Orientation weeks taught me how to explain complicated procedures in an understandable and encouraging manner so they felt confident and educated about their financial aid. These experiences allow me to position myself as both detail oriented and student

focused, demonstrating my ability to maintain accuracy behind the scenes while also engaging effectively with the individuals impacted by the work.

Even though the EMPAC model was designed for retail, I found it connects well to financial aid. For example, Entertainment came through during Orientation weeks I worked, where approachable and supportive interactions helped students feel less stressed about finances, jobs, and more comfortable asking questions. Matching was at the heart of what we did, since every student's situation was different and it was important to connect them with the right combination of scholarships, grants, loans, or work-study opportunities. Price was a clear factor too, because each adjustment to a student's aid package directly shaped how affordable their education became. The assortment of options mattered, since offering multiple pathways for funding gave students flexibility and a greater chance to find support that fit their needs. Finally, convenience played a big role through organized records, timely processing, and clear communication. We helped students avoid delays and confusion. Looking at my summer work through the EMPAC model helped me realize that financial aid, like retail, is about creating value for people by balancing accuracy, choice, and support. Although my role at the Financial Aid Office does not perfectly align with the EMPAC model, I approached the framework from a different perspective to draw meaningful connections to my experience.

Overall, my internship at the Financial Aid Office taught me that accuracy, confidentiality, and communication all play an equally important role in supporting students' access to higher education. I strengthened my technical skills through data management and reconciliation, but I also gained a deeper appreciation for the human side of financial aid, listening, explaining, and guiding students through a complex process. This experience not only

sharpened my attention to detail but also reinforced my commitment to equity in education by ensuring students receive the resources they need to succeed.